

Readings

Threads

James A. Autry - Love & Profit

Sometimes you just connect,
like that,
no big thing maybe
but something beyond the usual business stuff.
It comes and goes quickly
so you have to pay attention,
a change in the eyes
when you ask about the family,
a pain flickering behind the statistics
about a boy and a girl in school,
or about seeing them every other Sunday.
An older guy talks about his bride,
a little affectation after twenty-five years.
A hot-eyed achiever laughs before you want him to.
Someone tells about his wife's job
or why she quit working to stay home.
An old joker needs another laugh on the way
to retirement.
A woman says she spends a lot of her salary
on an au pair
and a good one is hard to find
but worth it because there is nothing more important
than the baby.
Listen.
In every office
you hear the threads
of love and joy and fear and guilt,
the cries for celebration or reassurance,
and somehow you know that connecting those threads
is what you are supposed to do
and business will take care of itself.

Kitchen Table Wisdom - Rachel Naomi Remen

Listening is the oldest and perhaps the most powerful tool of healing. It is often through the quality of our listening and not the wisdom of our words that we are able to effect the most profound changes in the people around us. When we listen, we offer with our attention an opportunity for wholeness. Our listening creates sanctuary for the homeless parts within the other person. That which has been denied, unloved, devalued by themselves and others. That which is hidden.

In this culture the soul and the heart too often go homeless. Listening creates a holy silence. When you listen generously to people, they can hear the truth in themselves, often for the first time. And in the silence of listening, you can know yourself in everyone. Eventually, you may be able to hear, in everyone and beyond everyone, the unseen singing softly to itself and to you.

Ten Commandments for Active Listening

Richard Rupp, MFT

1. Stop talking! You can't listen if you're talking. You have two ears and one mouth. Use them in that ratio.
2. Put the other person at ease. Help the other to feel relaxed and free to talk.
3. Prove that you want to listen. Use two eyes and two ears. Act interested. Make encouraging nods and words like "uh huh", "go on," and "what else?" Listen to understand vs. to defend.
4. Remove distractions. Don't scroll through your phone, channel surf the TV or read the newspaper or emails while the other talks.
5. Empathize. Empathize. Empathize. Put yourself into the other person's shoes.
6. Be patient. Allow the other person time to speak. Don't interrupt or complete the other's sentences.
7. Don't attack or criticize. This puts the other on the defensive. He or she may clam up and quit talking. Don't throw a hardball at the other. Toss a softball that can be caught. Think of talking as playing a game of catch. Don't try to bean the other person with a fastball.
8. Ask questions. This develops more understanding. "So what you are saying is?" "Is this what you mean?" "So you are feeling..." "That's interesting, go on." Reflect, Confirm, Clarify, Summarize.
9. Hold your temper. Anger throws out understanding as well as reason.
10. Stop talking! This is the first and the last because all the rest depend on this for listening. Remember you have two ears and one mouth. Use in that ratio.

"Well, talking to girls is easy. They'll tell you everything. The secret to talking is listening"

Benjamin Mee, author - We Bought a Zoo

"Being listened to and heard is one of the greatest desires of the human heart. And those who learn to listen are the most loved and respected."

Richard Carlson ,author - Don't Sweat the Small Stuff

Listen Carefully

It's an almost universal truth: Everyone thinks they are a good driver. Everyone also thinks they have a good sense of humor. And everyone thinks they are a good listener.

Remember learning about communication, how it can be broken down in the components of sending, receiving, and interpreting messages? Most of us have been taught how to actively listen. Focus on the other person, hear what they say, the importance of repeating back to them what we heard. It takes energy to listen carefully to another person. It can be hard.

When I was teaching chaplaincy students, I remember one woman coming to me. She was just exhausted. She said that she didn't think she could become a chaplain. She found that it took so much energy to really listen to other people. It was taxing to keep track of the details, notice the inflections, pay attention to the small movements, observe the changes in tone and cadence. To truly hear others was burdensome. It was not something she could sustain.

Fortunately, there's another way to listen. It's easier, less exhausting, more efficient, and it is enjoyable. Careful listening should be something that blesses both the speaker and the receiver.

I learned about it when listening to alcoholic and addicts 5th steps. I was serving as a chaplain in a drug rehab facility that used the Alcoholic Anonymous 12 Steps. We asked the patients to do the 4th step. Make "a searching and fearless moral inventory of" themselves. We suggested they write out all of their deepest secrets, their shames, their mistakes and negative character traits. We had written guides and prompts to help them with this task.

Then came the dreaded 5th step: "Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs." This is the kicker - they had to tell a real person - not just look at it themselves or pray about it or meditate on their misdeeds. They had to share their worst stuff with another living person.

There is something tremendously healing about telling someone the specific details of your most wretched self and have that person receive it. They don't run out of the room, or gasp, or squirm. They just listen.

This is how I understand the religious idea of confession.

When I started receiving 5th Steps as a new chaplain, it was taxing. It was hard to remember everything I was being told and then figuring out what I was going to say. I was often trashed at the end of the day.

When I learned about passive or impact listening, I started to enjoy hearing 5th steps. I looked forward to them. It was important that the patients write out their 4th step, remember their lives and organize their thoughts. Yet instead of just asking them to read their 4th steps to me, I asked them to tell me their story. How did they come to be sitting with me in a room at a drug rehab facility?

It was a fascinating experience. When I go to a movie, I can often guess how the story will go. Yet sitting in that room, all I really know of that person's story is they are alive and here. Life stories don't follow a predetermined arch.

I discovered that I could sit and silently listen for 2 or more hours. I heard better and remembered the details and knew what to say. This was so much better than active listening.

It is listening differently. I learned to let my mind be open and soft. It was similar to the difference between high impact and low impact aerobics. Both burned calories and toned the body, but one hurts a lot less!

This listening doesn't focus on content. You let your mind go blank. Let the other person's words flow over you. Just listen.

When it is time for a response, you'll usually be able to respond with heart. You'll be able to say something about the emotion under the words.

"Oh, it sounds like that surprised you." "Did that make you feel ticked off?" "Was that confusing for you?" "Your voice sounded tickled as you told that story."

This is so different from the way it usually goes. I bet you've been on both sides of this scene. You come home from work or errands and your partner starts to tell you about their day. The kids acted up. There was a problem with a neighbor. The dog got out and chased the mail carrier. And to top it off, Fred the guinea pig had babies. You get dumped on.

So, the partner who just came home listens. And then, with the best of intentions, begins to give advice. Oh, that never goes well. And what does the story teller say? "I don't need fixing. I just wanted to be heard!"

The content doesn't matter. What does is the desire for connection. The point isn't the words. It's the feelings the words are about. Remember when teenagers would talk on the phone for hours and not really have anything to say. The whole point of the conversation was just to connect.

When I received 5th Steps with this passive listening, I wasn't focused on the content; although I did take it in and hear it. My goal was to allow for connection. As chaplains, we noticed that we never got bored when we heard a good 5th Step. The patient was present and we were engaged. If we were bored, it meant that one of us wasn't fully there.

What's interesting is that when we listen from such an open place, we often take in more information. I've found this to be true when I've experimented by contrasting the way I normally take notes for a class or presentation and what I retain when I listen passively. There are times I still want to take notes, but far fewer.

When the presenter is passionate about the topic, or excited, or intrigued, it is even easier.

When I listen this way, I'm listening for impact. Rather than getting information for my head, I want to be impacted by my own response to the other person. And this comes very naturally. It isn't something you have to learn. If you listen with a quiet mind and an open heart, you will typically feel either compassion or joy. I'm not trying to feel what the other person is feeling. I am setting myself up to connect, but not mimic.

When I feel compassion for another, or feel joy with them, I rarely feel responsible. I don't have to fix things for them. And most people don't want to be fixed. It's always a top down position. Fixing leads to resentment - both for the person being fixed, and for the one doing the fixing. When I feel compassion, I also trust and respect that the person can find a way. And even if I'm listening as a counselor and my goal is to help them, I can approach from an equal place, as a caring human, rather than the all powerful expert.

Think about how it is when you feel heard - when someone gets what you are saying and there is no judgement. Maybe there's a little bit of

curiosity. Our own minds and hearts become more quiet. Things feel more roomy. The other person doesn't have to agree with us, as long as we've been heard.

When we don't feel heard, we use more words. In this way, passive listening is efficient. Just reciting content doesn't give the speaker what they need. We'll just keep giving more content, until we're both worn out.

And if we are listening for impact and just can't connect, can't find the emotion behind the words, it is ok to just ask - "What stood out to you about that event?" "Was there something that brought up for you?" We aren't trying to do therapy on the speaker. We are trying to let ourselves be touched.

While this type of listening is easy, it is not mindless. It's not something you can do while you scroll on your phone or answer emails. It requires that we are present. If we're in the same room with someone, it means that we put down what we're doing and give the other person our attention, generously. Position our body so that we are facing them. Point our feet so that they are going toward the other person.

If you are really wanting to get back to your phone or your program, try an experiment. Chances are that if you give yourself over, open your heart and mind and listen, your talker will feel that you are involved and actually be quicker about the time they need. If you are only marginally there, wishing the other would quit sharing such inane trivia and wondering when they will shut up so you can get back to your project or phone in peace, chances are they will talk longer, or louder, or use even more words. They won't stop until they get your attention, or until they give up.

It's also fair to tell someone, "I can't hear you right now. Let's come back to this later when I'm able to listen." Just make sure you follow through.

Thank goodness that passive listening gives us a different experience. As we age, we begin to hear the same stories and information again and again. Within literature, there are only 7 types of basic stories - Overcoming The Monster, Rags To Riches, The Quest, Voyage & Return, Comedy, Tragedy, and Rebirth. Fortunately, there is a great variety in the telling.

This was really brought home to me one day when I was the chaplain for our mental health day program. There were two women with the same story of adultery. They had almost identical tales. Both women were married, had promised monogamy to their partners and they had each had an affair. They had ended the affairs, but were stuck and someone suggested they talk to the chaplain.

The first woman and I met and she told me her story. I listened. As I heard beneath the words, it became clear that she was grieving. She didn't know it was ok to miss her lover. It was a secret, disenfranchised grief, not something she could share. She thought she must be wrong for feeling that way. She had gotten stuck and was afraid she was being punished. Instead, she was just being human. Once she understood that her grief was normal and that she wasn't bad for missing a person she had enjoyed, she felt like she could move on. She could grieve for what she had and recommit to her marriage to make it better.

The second woman comes in and tells me the same story. At first I think, "OK, this is going to be easy"... but it turns out she wasn't stuck in grief. She felt terrible about what she had done and didn't think she could be forgiven. This woman was a Christian and as a chaplain, I try to work within a patient's theology. This woman believed that God could forgive adulterers. She believed that God could forgive anything. Yet in her mind, God, who could forgive anyone, anything, could not forgive her.

That's when I heard her. She was terminally unique. She and her sin were so bad they were beyond God's compassion. Fortunately, she was able to see the humor in her grandiose thinking. She was bigger than God! It was only after I heard her that we made any progress and she was able to challenge that nonsensical thought.

Professionally, impact listening has made my ministry better and easier. The less I think when I listen, the better responses I have.

It's also made my life better at home. With his permission, Bob has said that I can share this. Before he heard about impact listening, it was hard on Bob to listen to me talk about my day. Especially when work has been tough, he has listened to my angst and woe and yet not known how to make it right. And Bob loves me. He wants to fix things, even if I say I just need him to listen. Bob now has an answer to his question of "What

am I supposed to do?" He can relax, open up to hear me, let himself be touched by me, and then reflect back what emotion he heard. That's the most powerful thing he can do.

You may not choose to use this form of deep listening all the time. There may be times you would really rather just scroll on your phone and make some noise as another person blathers on. Sometimes that is not an inappropriate choice. Sometimes you may choose to focus on the details of the information itself. Connection may not be your goal or even a necessary part of the equation. Still, it is a gift to know that there is a way to pay attention to others that actually makes us feel better for listening, even if the content itself is not uplifting. There is a way to carefully hear others that does not drain our energy or feel like a chore.

As you go forward this week, I invite you to listen, deeply, passively, quietly. Do not struggle to hear, but open your heart and your mind. Experiment with this. See what happens when you aren't focusing on the particulars and when you allow yourself to be touched by the person.

Paul Tillich, a great theologian, has said, "The first duty of love is to listen."

May you listen with ease and grace.

May you silence your mind and hear more than the words.

May you teach others how to listen beautifully to you.

And may we all be better listeners than we are drivers!

Amen and Amen